Was it really AI?

An evidence audit of the first business failures blamed on generative AI

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Getty Images' bankruptcy was widely reported as one of the first business failures caused by AI. Its own court filing says AI pressures "would not alone have necessitated" it. This study compared the documented causes of eight AI-linked business failures with how the news explained them. Only two companies' own documents name AI as the main cause, and neither has gone bankrupt.

36	8	55	2
BUSINESSES SCREENED	CASES CODED IN DEPTH	NEWS ARTICLES SCORED	AI DOCUMENTED AS MAIN CAUSE

ABSTRACT

When Getty Images filed for Chapter 11 bankruptcy on 21 October 2026, much of the coverage presented it as one of the first businesses brought down by generative AI. This study asks how far that story, and others like it, is supported by the documents. Thirty-six businesses publicly linked to AI were screened against a fixed inclusion rule. Eighteen had a qualifying failure event between January 2024 and October 2026, and eight were coded in depth. For each case, every cause named in court filings, regulated company disclosures, regulator decisions and analyst statements was coded by category, weight and evidence grade. Every news article published within 14 days of the failure event, up to 12 per case (55 in total), was scored for how strongly it attributed the failure to AI. Only two businesses, the homework-help company Chegg and the music site Stereogum, had their own documents naming AI as the main cause, and neither has gone bankrupt. No bankruptcy in the sample was documented as caused by AI. Getty's own disclosure statement says that AI-related pressures "would not alone have necessitated" the filing and names three other causes: litigation judgments, the costs of a failed merger, and an unsustainable debt load. Yet 8 of 12 articles about Getty named AI as a cause, and two headlines named it as the main one. Where AI really was the main cause, news coverage matched the documents. The gap between the story and the record was concentrated in the high-profile bankruptcies of companies associated with AI. The paper ends with a seven-question checklist for judging whether AI was really the cause of a business failure.

Keywords: generative AI; business failure; Getty Images; media framing; causal attribution; case study

KEY FINDINGS

1. Of 36 businesses screened, 18 had a qualifying failure event and 8 were coded in depth. Only 2, Chegg and Stereogum, have their own documents naming AI as the main cause. Both are still trading.
2. No bankruptcy in the sample was documented as caused by AI. Getty's court disclosure says AI pressures were "manageable" and "would not alone have necessitated" Chapter 11; the filing was "primarily driven by three non-operational events": litigation, merger costs and debt.
3. The news story ran ahead of the record for Getty: 8 of 12 articles named AI as a cause, against a documented AI weight of "background only".
4. Where AI was documented as the main cause, coverage matched it closely (Chegg: 10 of 11 articles). Overstatement was concentrated in a few high-profile cases, not spread across all of them.
5. The AI companies that failed (Character.AI, Builder.ai, iLearningEngines) failed for familiar reasons: running costs, lawsuits, financing and alleged fraud. None was documented as beaten by rival AI.

1 Introduction

Generative AI has been widely expected to displace parts of the economy, and since 2023 the search for its first corporate casualties has become a recurring news story. In April 2026, one business title called Chegg "the first company to be completely wiped out by AI" (Entrepreneur, 2026). When Getty Images, the world's best-known stock photo library, filed for Chapter 11 in October 2026, some headlines put AI at the centre of the story, for example "Getty Images plans bankruptcy as AI shakes up stock photos" (Lee, 2026).

These claims matter beyond the companies involved. Investors, employees, regulators and other businesses use them to judge which sectors are at risk, and consultants use them to advise clients. If the story that "AI did it" is wrong, people may protect themselves against the wrong threat and miss the real one, such as debt, litigation or a failing strategy.

Causes of business failure are hard to establish. Failures usually have several causes, companies have reasons to emphasise some causes over others, and journalists work to short deadlines with limited information. A long line of research has shown that companies tend to explain bad results by pointing to factors outside their control (Bettman & Weitz, 1983; Salancik & Meindl, 1984), and that simplified or exaggerated causal claims in press releases often pass into news coverage (Sumner et al., 2014). There is also a reverse risk. Companies sometimes overstate how much AI they use, a practice regulators now call "AI washing" (Securities and Exchange Commission, 2024), so the word "AI" can appear in a failure story for reasons that have nothing to do with competition from AI.

This study audits the evidence for the first wave of business failures blamed on generative AI. It asks three questions:

1. What do primary documents (court filings, regulated company disclosures, regulator decisions and analyst statements) show about the causes of each failure?
2. How strongly does news coverage attribute each failure to AI, and how far is that from the documented causes?

3. Which business models show the clearest documented harm from AI, and what warning signs came first?

The contribution is a repeatable method for weighing AI's part in a business failure, its first results across eight cases, and a practical checklist. Section 2 reviews the background. Section 3 sets out the method, which was fixed before data collection. Section 4 presents the results, case by case and then across the news coverage. Sections 5 to 8 discuss the findings, set out the checklist, state the limitations and conclude.

2 Background

2.1 Evidence that generative AI replaces some paid work

There is good evidence that generative AI reduces demand for some kinds of paid work. On a large online freelancing platform, freelancers in the occupations most exposed to generative AI saw fewer jobs and lower earnings after ChatGPT and image generators were released (Hui et al., 2024). On the web, independent studies agree that Google's AI Overviews, launched in the United States in May 2024, reduce clicks on the searches where they appear. In Pew Research Center's browsing panel, users who saw an AI summary clicked a traditional search result in 8% of visits, against 15% for those who did not (Pew Research Center, 2025). An analysis of 300,000 keywords found that an AI Overview was associated with a 34.5% lower click-through rate for the top-ranked page (Ahrefs, 2025). Google disputes the size of the effect at the level of the whole web, saying that "total organic click volume from Google Search to websites has been relatively stable year-over-year" (Reid, 2025).

Lower demand is not the same as failure, however. Disruption theory has long described incumbents being undercut by cheaper, "good enough" alternatives (Christensen, 1997), but whether a company fails depends on much more than one competitor: its debts, its costs, its strategy and the cash it has to adapt.

2.2 How failures get explained

Company explanations of poor results are self-interested. Studies of annual reports found that companies tend to attribute bad outcomes to external causes and good outcomes to their own actions (Bettman & Weitz, 1983; Salancik & Meindl, 1984). In a bankruptcy, the incentive can run either way. A company seeking court approval for a restructuring wants to show that its underlying business is sound, which favours blaming one-off events. A company suing a competitor wants to show that the competitor caused its losses. News coverage then adds its own simplifications: in health science, exaggerated causal claims in press releases were strongly associated with exaggerated news stories (Sumner et al., 2014). No study we found had systematically compared the documented causes of AI-linked business failures with how they were reported.

3 Method

3.1 Design

This is a qualitative multiple-case study (Yin, 2018) using document analysis, combined with a content analysis of news coverage. The coding protocol, including the inclusion rule, the cause categories, the weights, the evidence grades and the framing scale, was written and dated on 24

October 2026, before any case data were collected. All data were collected and coded on 24 October 2026.

3.2 Case selection

A business was included if a named news outlet had publicly linked it to AI, and it had a failure event between 1 January 2024 and 24 October 2026. A failure event was a bankruptcy or insolvency filing, a closure, a stock-exchange delisting notice, or a documented fall in revenue or traffic of 50% or more. Share-price falls, layoffs and profit warnings alone did not count.

Candidates came from a systematic web search using fixed search strings (for example "first company killed by AI", "AI put us out of business" and sector terms for translation, stock images, call centres, freelancing, education and publishing), plus the cases most often named in coverage. Thirty-six businesses were screened and eighteen met the rule. Every exclusion was recorded with its reason. For example, Teleperformance, Fiverr and Upwork were excluded because their AI-related problems were share-price falls, layoffs or guidance cuts rather than qualifying failure events, and Stack Overflow was excluded because its widely reported decline is in questions posted, not in revenue or traffic.

Eight of the eighteen were coded in depth. They were chosen to cover three groups, since a failure can be linked to AI in three quite different ways:

- **Group A, incumbents said to be disrupted by AI:** Getty Images, Chegg, and three web publishers (Stereogum, The Planet D and Giant Freakin Robot).
- **Group B, AI companies that failed:** Character.AI.
- **Group C, companies where AI was the story rather than the cause:** Builder.ai and iLearningEngines.

The other ten eligible businesses were screened but not coded in depth. None of them had a court filing, regulated disclosure or analyst statement naming competition from AI as a cause.

3.3 Sources and evidence grades

For each case, the primary documents were sought first: court filings (Chapter 11 and Chapter 7 petitions, first-day declarations and disclosure statements), filings with the US Securities and Exchange Commission (results releases, 10-K risk factors and 8-K reports), regulator decisions, and published statements by the owners of small private companies. Independent analyst statements, court judgments and peer-reviewed studies came next, followed by news reports. Each source was given an evidence grade:

- **A:** the company's own sworn or regulated statement, or for a small private company, its owner's public statement.
- **B:** an independent analyst, regulator, court or peer-reviewed study.
- **C:** a journalist's characterisation.
- **D:** social media or blogs.

Only text that was actually retrieved was quoted. Where a source could not be retrieved, it was marked unverified and not used as evidence.

3.4 Coding the documented causes

Every cause named in a source was coded with a category, a weight and the source's grade (Table 1).

Table 1. The coding scheme, fixed before data collection

FIELD	VALUES
Cause category	AI; debt or financing; litigation; regulation; management, strategy or deals; market; other technology (for example search-ranking changes or lost social-media referrals); fraud or governance; operating cost
Weight	3 = named as the main or first cause; 2 = named as a cause; 1 = mentioned only as background, risk or context; 0 = not mentioned
Evidence grade	A, B, C or D, as in Section 3.3
News framing score	0 = AI not mentioned; 1 = AI as background only; 2 = AI named as one of several causes; 3 = AI presented as the main cause, or named as the cause in the headline

The **documented AI weight** for a case is the highest weight given to AI by any grade A or B source. Where a case had no grade A or B source, grade C sources were used and the case was flagged. This rule deliberately favours the most authoritative account, while recording all other claims.

3.5 News sample

For each case, news articles about the failure event published within 14 days either side of it were collected, one per outlet and up to 12 per case. Wire services and major business and technology titles were sought first, then other outlets found through news search. Where a case had several events, the sample was taken around the most-covered one (for Chegg, the 27 October 2025 announcement of 45% job cuts and the end of its strategic review). Each article was scored on the framing scale in Table 1, with the quoted sentence that justified the score. In total, 55 articles were scored.

3.6 Analysis

For each case, the mean framing score of its articles was compared with its documented AI weight. Both are on a 0 to 3 scale. The **gap** is the mean framing score minus the documented AI weight: a positive gap means the news gave AI a larger role than the documents did. With eight cases, the analysis is descriptive; no statistical tests were run.

4 Results

4.1 Overview

Table 2 and Figure 1 summarise the eight cases. Only two had grade A documents naming AI as the main cause: Chegg and Stereogum. A third, The Planet D, was reported as an AI casualty, but no statement by its owners could be found, so its AI weight rests on a journalist's account and is flagged. In the other five cases, the documents gave AI either a background role or none at all.

Table 2. Documented causes and news framing for the eight cases (AI weight and framing on a 0 to 3 scale)

CASE	GROUP	FAILURE EVENT	MAIN DOCUMENTED CAUSES	DOCUMENTED AI WEIGHT	NEWS FRAMING (MEAN)	ARTICLES	GAP
Builder.ai	C	Insolvency; Chapter 7 (May–Jun 2025)	Lender seized cash; revenue overstatement (reported)	0	1.00	10	+1.00
Getty Images	A	Chapter 11 (21 Oct 2026)	Litigation, merger costs, debt	1	1.67	12	+0.67
Character.AI	B	Chapter 11 (12 Oct 2026)	Running costs, lawsuits and regulation, failed fundraising	0	0.42	12	+0.42
Stereogum	A	Ad revenue down 70% (2025)	AI search (Google AI Overviews)	3	3.00	2	0.00
The Planet D	A	Traffic down 90% (reported Apr 2025)	AI search, as reported by Bloomberg*	3*	3.00	3	0.00
iLearningEngines	C	Chapter 11 (20 Dec 2024)	Alleged fraud, lost financing	0	0.00	2	0.00
Chegg	A	Revenue down 51% (2021–2025)	AI (Google AI Overviews and ChatGPT)	3	2.73	11	−0.27
Giant Freakin Robot	A	Closure (4 Nov 2024)	Google search-ranking changes	1	0.67	3	−0.33

* No grade A or B source was found; the weight rests on grade C reporting.

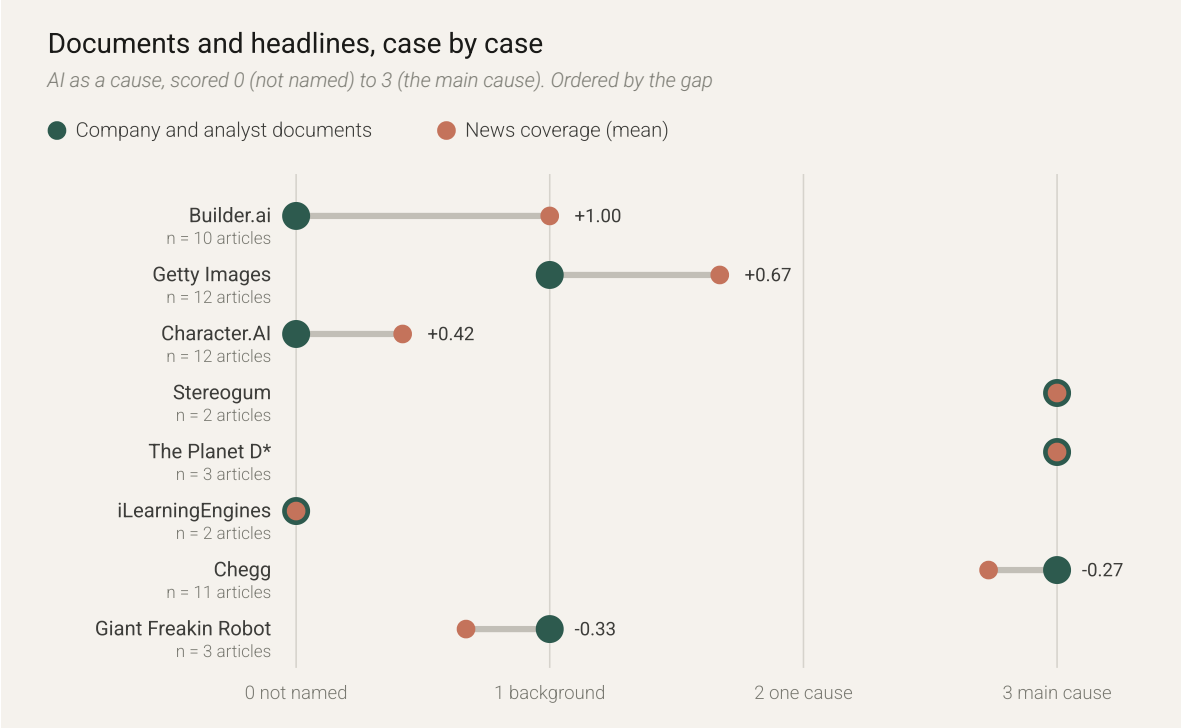


Figure 1. The documented weight of AI as a cause (green) against the mean news framing score (orange) for each case. A gap to the right means the news gave AI a larger role than the documents did. * Grade C evidence only.

4.2 Getty Images: an AI story, a debt bankruptcy

Getty filed a prepackaged Chapter 11 case in Delaware on 21 October 2026, after agreeing a restructuring with its lenders under which the Getty family and Koch Equity Development will provide up to $533 million of new equity and take the company private (Reuters, 2026). Its disclosure statement, filed with the US Securities and Exchange Commission the same day, is the company's own account of why. It says that "the filing of these Chapter 11 Cases was primarily driven by three non-operational events": the warrant litigation and the resulting judgments (over $200 million in judgments and interest), "the fees and debt incurred in pursuit of the proposed Shutterstock merger" (more than $100 million in fees), and "the unsustainable debt service burden and cost of the Company's capital structure", put at about $239 million a year (Getty Images, 2026b).

The merger had been abandoned in July 2026. The UK Competition and Markets Authority had found that it could reduce competition in UK editorial content and would allow it only if Shutterstock's entire editorial business was sold, which Getty refused (Competition and Markets Authority, 2026). The independent analyst view matches the company's: an S&P Global analyst described debt and litigation payments as "probably the main bad driver" (Halverson, 2026).

AI does appear in the disclosure statement, but as background. Under "Broader Industry Headwinds", Getty says that it "has experienced structural shifts, including the emergence of generative AI and changes in media consumption and marketing strategies", felt "principally in the Company's iStock brand" and among agency customers. Purchasing customers in those groups fell by about 24% between 2022 and mid-2026 (Figure 2), and annual subscribers fell from 321,000 to 240,000 in a year. The statement then says: "These trends affecting iStock and agency customers, while requiring ongoing strategic attention, are manageable and would not alone have necessitated the

commencement of these Chapter 11 Cases" (Getty Images, 2026b). Elsewhere it describes the "budget-conscious microstock image market" under pressure from AI as "only a small portion" of the business.

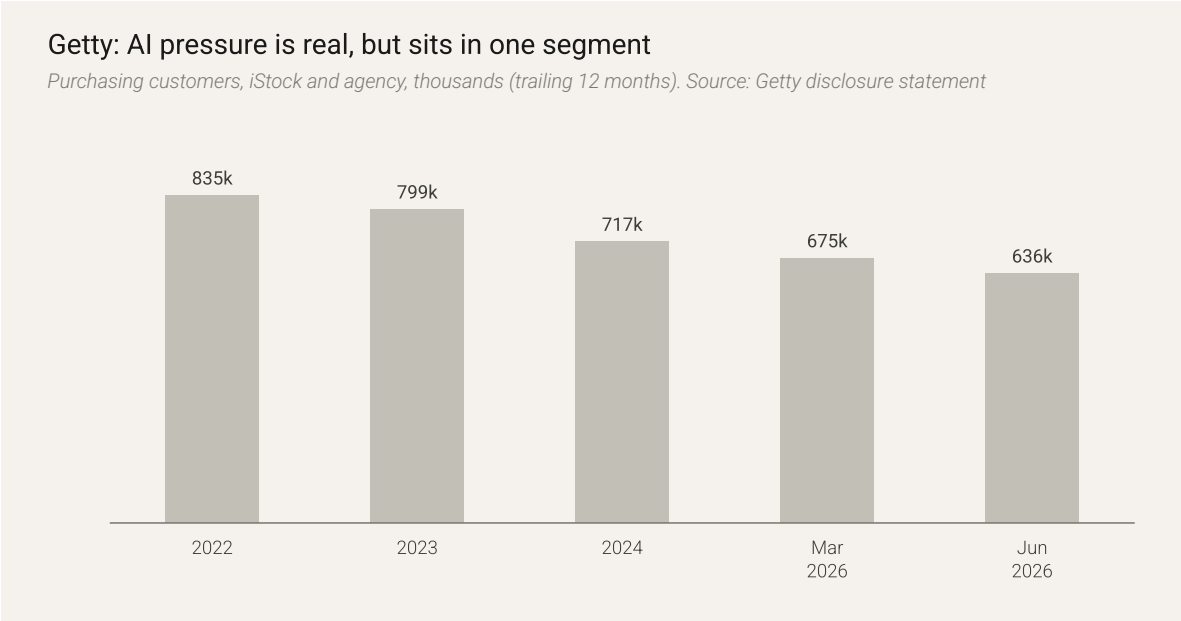


Figure 2. Getty Images: purchasing customers in its iStock and agency segments, the part of the business Getty says is exposed to generative AI. Source: Getty Images (2026b).

The wider financial results are consistent with this account. Getty's revenue grew in 2025, and in the second quarter of 2026 creative revenue fell 2.6% while editorial revenue rose 9.2% (Getty Images, 2026a). The Competition and Markets Authority did treat generative AI as a real competitive force, concluding that "large GenAI firms will increasingly act as a constraint" on Getty and Shutterstock (Competition and Markets Authority, 2026). Getty had also mostly lost its UK copyright case against Stability AI (Getty Images (US) Inc v Stability AI Ltd, 2025).

Two cautions apply. A disclosure statement supports a restructuring plan, so the company has a reason to describe its business as "strong" and its problems as one-off. And AI pressure may have made the debt harder to carry even if it did not cause the filing. Under the protocol, AI is coded at weight 1 (background) on grade A and B evidence, but this case shows that "documented" and "true" are not the same thing.

4.3 Chegg: the clearest documented AI case

Chegg, an online homework-help company, is the case where the documents most clearly name AI. Its revenue fell from $776.3 million in 2021 to $376.9 million in 2025, a fall of 51% (Figure 3). In May 2023 the company said "we saw a significant spike in student interest in ChatGPT. We now believe it's having an impact on our new customer growth rate" (Chegg, 2023), and a peer-reviewed event study found that its share price fell by almost 50% after that warning (Pietrzak, 2025). In February 2025 Chegg said it "would not need to review strategic alternatives if Google hadn't launched AI Overviews" (Chegg, 2025a) and sued Google. In October 2025, announcing that it would cut 45% of its workforce, it said "the new realities of AI and reduced traffic from Google to content publishers have led to a significant decline in Chegg's traffic and revenue" (Chegg, 2025b).

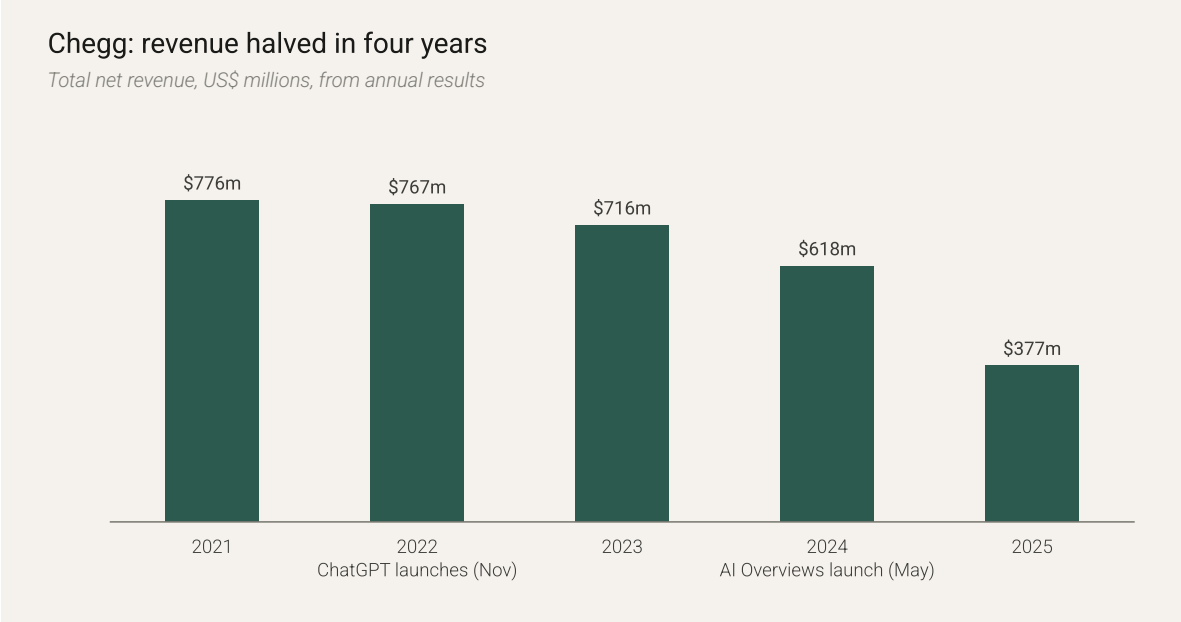


Figure 3. Chegg: total net revenue, 2021 to 2025, from its annual results.

AI is coded at weight 3 for Chegg. Two qualifications are recorded. First, from February 2025 Chegg's statements supported a damages claim against Google, so they were not neutral. The court dismissed that claim on antitrust grounds on 30 September 2026 without deciding what had caused Chegg's decline (Chegg, Inc. v. Google LLC, 2026). Second, some decline began before generative AI: Chegg's growth slowed as pandemic-era online learning faded in late 2021, and its own 10-K concedes that its "updated user experience and investments in AI have not attracted as many new students" as hoped (Chegg, 2026). Even Google's defence named a different AI, ChatGPT, as the cause. The dispute is about which AI, not whether AI played the main part. Chegg is still listed, so "wiped out" (Entrepreneur, 2026) overstates the outcome, but this is the one large company in the sample where the record supports AI as the main cause.

4.4 Web publishers: real damage, tangled causes

Stereogum's founder wrote in November 2025 that "the so-called media traffic apocalypse caused by Google's pivot to AI search has cut our ad revenue by 70%" (Lapatine, 2025). He noted that the site had set a new traffic record every year since 2020, which rules out the earlier Google search updates as the main cause, and that lost referrals from Facebook and X had "hurt too". Stereogum did not close; it moved readers to a subscription model.

The Planet D, a travel blog, was reported by Bloomberg as having lost about 90% of its traffic after AI Overviews launched (Bloomberg News, 2025a). No statement by the owners themselves could be retrieved, and the blog's own publishing rate had roughly halved between 2023 and 2024, a period that also included Google's major 2023 and 2024 search updates. Its AI weight therefore rests on grade C evidence and is flagged.

Giant Freakin Robot, an entertainment news site, stopped publishing new articles in November 2024. Its owner blamed Google's ranking decisions, which he said had handed "most entertainment keywords" to a few large companies, and dated the decline to 2022. AI appears in his account only as a further grievance about content being scraped (Tyler, 2024). Most coverage followed his explanation.

These cases fit the wider evidence that AI summaries reduce clicks (Pew Research Center, 2025; Ahrefs, 2025). But case-level falls of 70% to 90% are much larger than the average effects measured, and for small sites the effects of AI search, ordinary search-ranking changes and lost social-media traffic are hard to separate. Of the three, only Stereogum provides a first-hand account that clearly names AI and gives reasons to rule out the alternatives.

4.5 AI companies that failed

Character.AI, a chatbot company, filed for Chapter 11 on 12 October 2026, with a Disney affiliate bidding $20 million for a non-exclusive licence to its technology. Its chief executive's sworn declaration names the causes: compute costs (about $56.1 million in the first eight months of 2026, about 45% of operating expenses), lawsuits and regulatory investigations over child safety, the cost of safety changes including banning under-18s from open-ended chats, and an inability to raise new capital (Character Technologies, 2026). Being an AI company was central to its costs, but no grade A or B source says it lost to rival AI products. Its documented AI weight as a cause is therefore 0.

Builder.ai, a software-development company backed by Microsoft that marketed itself as AI-powered, entered insolvency in May 2025 after a lender seized most of its cash (Bloomberg News, 2025b), and its US parent filed for Chapter 7 liquidation in June 2025 (Engineer.ai Corporation, 2025). Reports of overstated revenue followed. A widely shared claim that its "AI" was really 700 human engineers was later corrected by the newsletter that had repeated it (Orosz, 2025). iLearningEngines, which described itself as an AI education company, filed for Chapter 11 in December 2024 after a short-seller report alleged that its revenue was largely fake (Hindenburg Research, 2024). The same report noted the company's "complete lack of focus on, and mention of, AI" in its earlier history. In both Group C cases, AI was the company's label, not a cause of its failure, and news coverage mostly treated it that way.

4.6 How the news explained the failures

Across all 55 articles, 14 did not mention AI, 17 mentioned it only as background, 7 named it as one of several causes, and 17 presented it as the main cause (Figure 4). The mean gap across the eight cases was small (+0.19 on the 0 to 3 scale), and in five cases the gap was zero or negative. The news did not systematically overstate AI's role.

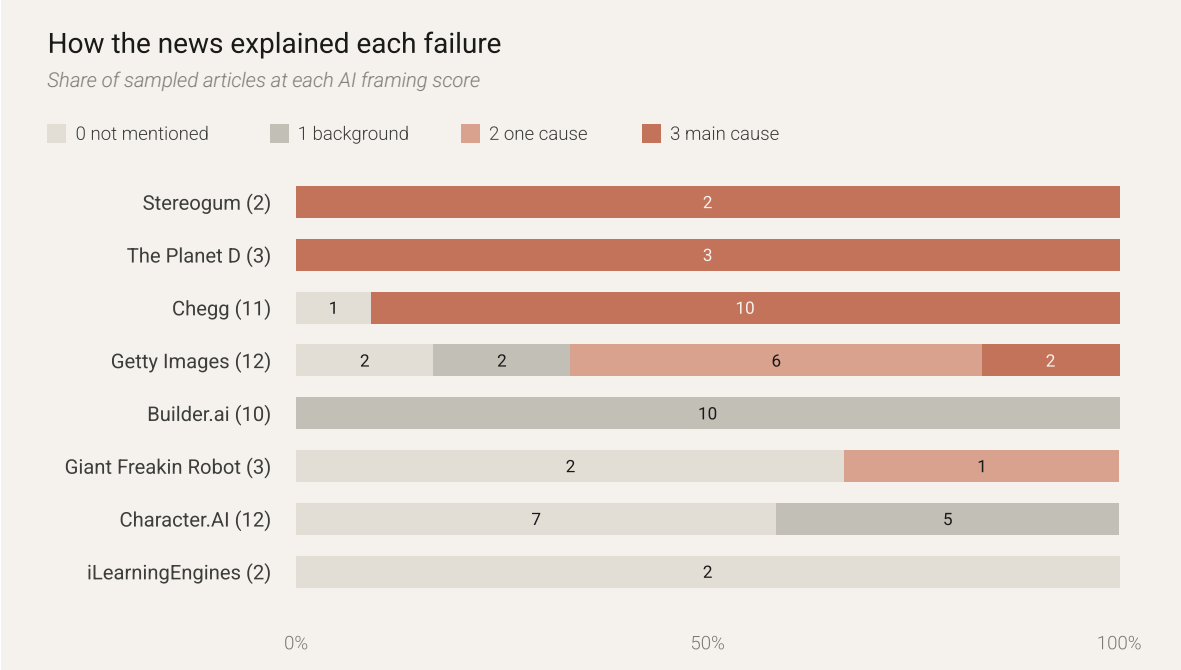


Figure 4. The share of sampled articles at each AI framing score, by case. Article counts in brackets.

The overstatement was concentrated in the high-profile bankruptcies of companies associated with AI, and above all in Getty. Eight of the 12 Getty articles named AI as a cause, and two headlines named it as the main one. In one of these, the headline said Getty was planning bankruptcy "as AI shakes up stock photos", while the article itself noted that the company was not attributing the move to AI (Lee, 2026). Wire services were more measured: the Reuters report named AI as one factor alongside debt (score 2), and a Bloomberg news item did not mention AI (score 0). For Builder.ai, every article mentioned AI, as the company's identity rather than its cause of failure.

Where AI really was documented as the main cause, the coverage matched closely. Ten of the 11 Chegg articles presented AI as the main cause, closely tracking the company's own announcement, and Stereogum's founder's account was reported as he gave it.

5 Discussion

The first wave of business failures blamed on AI is smaller and more mixed than the headlines suggest. As of October 2026, this audit found no bankruptcy in which the company's own filings name competition from AI as the main cause. The clearest documented harm is not bankruptcy but erosion: a halving of revenue at Chegg and a 70% fall in advertising revenue at a music site, both concentrated in businesses that sell answers or attention to people who can now get a summary from an AI instead.

Getty shows why the distinction matters. Generative AI is a real pressure on its low-cost stock-photo segment, and the competition regulator expects it to grow. But the bankruptcy was driven by a balance sheet weakened by a lawsuit, a failed merger and debt, while the rest of the business kept growing. Reading Getty as "killed by AI" would teach the wrong lesson: the lesson of this case is about leverage and deal risk in a business facing a new competitor, not that the new competitor won.

The comparison between documents and coverage also shows where to be sceptical. Overstatement appeared where a famous company, a dramatic event and a fashionable explanation came together. Where a company itself blamed AI, the press repeated it faithfully, which is accurate reporting but also means the company's own interests pass straight into the news. Chegg was suing Google; Getty was seeking court approval for a plan. In both directions, the company's account deserves the same scrutiny as the headline.

Finally, the AI companies in the sample failed in ordinary ways. Character.AI ran out of money because its product was expensive to operate and legally risky; Builder.ai and iLearningEngines collapsed amid alleged misrepresentation. "AI company fails" and "AI kills company" are different stories, and the coverage mostly kept them apart.

6 A checklist: was it really AI?

The cases suggest seven questions for anyone, whether investor, journalist, employee or adviser, judging whether AI was really the cause of a business failure:

1. **Read the company's own account first.** In a bankruptcy, the first-day declaration and disclosure statement explain the causes in detail and under oath. Getty's took one paragraph to say that AI was not the reason.
2. **Separate the balance sheet from the business.** Litigation, deal costs and debt can sink a company whose customers are still buying. Check whether revenue actually fell before blaming a competitor.
3. **Find the exposed segment.** AI pressure often hits one part of a business (Getty's microstock segment, not its editorial work). Ask how large that part is.
4. **Check the timing.** Did the decline start before ChatGPT (November 2022) or AI Overviews (May 2024)? Were there other shocks at the same time, such as search-ranking updates or the end of pandemic demand?
5. **Ask who benefits from the explanation.** A company suing a rival, seeking court approval or raising money has reasons to tell a particular story.
6. **Distinguish "an AI company failed" from "AI killed the company".** Running costs, lawsuits and fraud are not evidence of AI disruption.
7. **Read past the headline.** In this sample, a headline sometimes named AI as the cause when the article below it did not.

7 Limitations

This is a small, purposive sample, chosen to cover different ways a failure can be linked to AI. It does not estimate how common AI-caused failures are. Each case was coded once against the fixed protocol, without a second independent coder, so no reliability statistic is reported. The "documented" weight measures what authoritative sources say, not the true cause: companies have incentives to play AI's role up or down, and the protocol cannot correct for that, as the Getty and Chegg cases show. The news samples for the publishers and for iLearningEngines were small (two or three articles each), so their gaps are indicative only. Some sources could not be retrieved, including Getty's first-day declaration and some paywalled articles; these were marked unverified and not used. Several

cases are still unfolding: Getty's restructuring is under way and its appeal against Stability AI is pending. Coverage was mainly from US and UK outlets. Finally, the framing scale gives a score of 1 to any article that mentions AI, so companies whose identity is AI (Builder.ai) start with a small positive gap.

8 Conclusion

Generative AI is already costing some businesses customers and revenue, and the evidence for that is solid in a few cases, above all Chegg. But the first bankruptcies to be described as AI casualties were mostly something else: Getty Images was brought to court by litigation, a failed merger and debt, and the AI companies that failed did so through costs, lawsuits and alleged fraud. The gap between story and record was largest exactly where attention was greatest. As more failures are blamed on AI, the useful question is not whether AI was involved, but whether the documents show that it was the cause.

Data and sources

The coding protocol, the case-selection log for all 36 screened businesses, the coded causes with their quotations, the scored news sample, and the analysis and chart scripts are available from the author on request. Every coded cause and every scored article is linked to its source.

Competing interests

The author declares no competing interests and holds no position in any company discussed.

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Responsible practice

The study uses only public documents and published news coverage, and involves no participants. It names companies, not private individuals, except where a company's owner or founder made the public statement being analysed. Allegations of fraud are described as allegations, with their source, and are not presented as findings of this study.

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